

THE SHELBY STAR

Balancing the scales: Carolina Raptor Center educates people, saves and protects vital birds of prey

By Jackie Bridges
Lifestyles Editor

Wings that once carried them through the sky are broken or missing.

Their sharp, curved talons can no longer seize prey.

They're prisoners.

The 73 birds at Charlotte's Carolina Raptor Center serve a life sentence because of irresponsible humans. Permanently injured, they can no longer survive in the wild.

Some were shot. Others, lured to the roadside by rodents feeding in litter on the highway, were hit by a car. A few were "rescued" by people who thought the parents had abandoned their baby birds.

"We get a lot of (supposedly) orphaned birds this time of year," said Pat Marcum, the Center's executive director.

"Baby birds will jump out of the nest. If anybody sees a baby bird with feathers, leave it because the parents are very attentive and will take care of it," she said. "A lot of well-meaning humans end up doing more damage than good."

Education of "well-meaning humans" is the Center's main goal. The raptors that live at the Center serve as living examples for educational programs at the Center's amphitheater or in schools or club meetings.

"It makes a difference for kids to get close to the birds," said Deborah Sue Griffin, the Center's education director. "If we can give the information and spark an interest — people will care for the birds and work to preserve and protect them."

Griffin has a biology degree from the University of North Carolina at Charlotte. She has been with the Center since it began in 1980 in the basement of the biology building on the UNCC campus.

Raptors — birds of prey — are important to the environment because they control the pest rodent species, such as rats, mice, squirrels and voles. They also help to keep down the numbers of snakes and lizards.

"Sometimes the children don't like to look at the vultures," Griffin said as she walked up to the cage where a shiny black vulture perched on a bar. As Griffin talked, the big bird turned to look in her direction.

"But I ask them what would happen if the garbage men went on a strike," she said.

"Well, vultures are nature's garbage men. When the kids realize that, they gain an appreciation for the birds."

Raptors also serve as environmental indicators, said a recent issue of the Center's newsletter. This means that when a toxin is in the environment, it shows up in raptors before it shows up in human tissues. This occurs



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Deborah Sue Griffin, education director, holds Sigmond, a red-tailed hawk that's used for educational programs at the Carolina Raptor Center.

to fly and build up its flight muscles. An attempt is made to release the bird near the location where it was found, if that is possible and appropriate.

Research is another priority for the Center. Hawks are watched each fall during the migration season and the Center participates



because birds have a much higher metabolism than humans.

Rehabilitation is another big part of the Center's work. More than 3,500 sick, injured or truly orphaned raptors are brought to the center by volunteers. Last month, there were 115 birds in the rehabilitation area.

Injured birds are examined and treated. Veterinarians donate their time for X-rays and surgery. A bird may spend from a few days to a few weeks in intensive care before it is moved outside to an exercise cage.

The final stage before release is spent in a large flight cage, where the bird is encouraged

each year in the Midwinter Bald Eagle Census. The Center also initiated the Osprey Introduction Project at nearby Lake Norman during the 1980s. Other research projects include raptor food requirements, behavior, prey selection, sexing techniques, pellet analysis and the development of young birds.

In 1989, a pair of golden eagles at the Center successfully hatched and raised the first chick in captivity in the southeastern United States. This young eagle was released

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Saving injured raptors

Injured raptors require immediate care by licensed and experienced raptor rehabilitators.

Call the Carolina Raptor Center for help immediately at 704-875-6521. The center does not accept small birds.

In the meantime:

Carefully catch the bird.

Watch out for its talons and beak. Even a weak bird will try to defend itself. A pair of heavy gloves should protect your hands. Carefully cover the bird with a towel, blanket or jacket to pick it up, taking care to fold its wings back against its body.

Place the bird in a sturdy cardboard box just a little larger than the bird. Put a blanket or towel in the bottom and cut ventilation holes near the base of the box. Place the box in a warm, quiet, dark place away from children or pets.

Do not try to water or feed the bird. Feeding it the wrong thing may kill it and it may not be strong enough to digest solid food.

If you find an orphaned or abandoned baby raptor. Make sure it is really abandoned before you pick it up. Young raptors sometimes spend time out of the nest while learning to fly.

Baby birds of prey will die within a short time if they are not fed properly. Well-meaning rescuers often condemn the babies they are trying to help by feeding them improperly. Do not attempt to feed the baby on your own without advice.



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This male bald eagle lost a wing when he was shot. He is called Sir Raleigh by the Raptor Center staff. Sir Raleigh and his mate, Queen Charlotte, have tried unsuccessfully to hatch and raise babies.



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Amanda Klint of Charlotte points out a bird to her daughter, Jennifer, 2. With the Klints is 9-year-old Ashley Smith. They visited the Raptor Center last week.



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This great horned owl, called Dudley by the Raptor Center staff, was rescued from becoming a lamp in someone's home. Dudley, whose injuries prevent him from living in the wild, now helps with educational programs.